

English Homework: Session 4

Would · Could · Should & Perfect Modals

Student: Ahmet (Gürkan)

Date: March 2026

Estimated Time: 1.5 hours

Next Lesson: Saturday / Sunday

Hi Ahmet,

You are making outstanding progress — your fluency and confidence are growing every week. This homework focuses entirely on **modal verbs**: *would*, *could*, *should* and their perfect forms *would have*, *could have*, *should have*. These are some of the most expressive tools in English — they let you talk about advice, regret, possibility, and hypothetical situations. Mastering them will take your speaking to a genuinely advanced level. Let's go!

1 1

Instructions: For each grammar point, (a) study the rule and correction, (b) write one original sentence in the box, and (c) note the rule in your own words below it.

1.1 Grammar Point 1: *Would* — Hypothetical & Polite

✗ **Common errors:** “I would to go.” / “I would going there.”

✓ **Correct:** “I **would** go there if I had the chance.”

✓ **Correct (polite):** “**Would** you like some coffee?” / “I **would like** to discuss this.”

Rule: *Would* is always followed by a **base verb** (no *to*, no *-ing*).

Use it for: **(1)** hypothetical situations (*If I were you, I would...*), **(2)** polite requests, **(3)** past habits (*When I worked at KGM, I would wake up at 6 every day.*)

▷ Write a sentence using *would* about a hypothetical situation in your career or life:

▷ Write the rule in your own words:

1.2 Grammar Point 2: *Could* — Ability & Possibility

✗ **Common errors:** “I can to do it yesterday.” / “Maybe it can happen — we are not sure.”

✓ **Past ability:** “When I was at KGM, I **could analyse** data very quickly.”

✓ **Possibility (present/future):** “AI **could change** road maintenance in the next decade.”

✓ **Polite suggestion:** “You **could try** using a different software for this.”

Rule: Use *could* for: (1) past ability, (2) present/future possibility (softer than *can*), (3) polite suggestions. Always followed by a **base verb**.

▷ Write one sentence using *could* for past ability and one for future possibility:

1.

2.

▷ Write the rule in your own words:

1.3 Grammar Point 3: *Should* — Advice & Obligation

✗ **Common errors:** “You should to update the system.” / “Engineers should working more carefully.”

✓ **Advice:** “The government **should share** road data publicly.”

✓ **Expectation:** “The results **should be** ready by Friday.”

✓ **Mild obligation:** “You **should back up** your data every day.”

Rule: *Should* is always followed by a **base verb**. It is softer than *must* — it gives advice or expresses what is expected, not a strict rule.

▷ Write a sentence giving advice to a young engineer in Turkey using *should*:

▷ Write the rule in your own words:

1.4 Grammar Point 4: Perfect Modals — Talking About the Past

These structures allow you to reflect on the past — to express regret, missed possibilities, or criticism.

Structure	Meaning	Example
<i>should have + past participle</i>	regret / criticism	“I should have started Geopave earlier.”
<i>could have + past participle</i>	missed possibility	“KGM could have used better data systems.”
<i>would have + past participle</i>	hypothetical past	“I would have retired sooner if I had known.”

✗ **Common errors:** “I should have went.” (*not went — use past participle: gone*)
 “I would have to do it.” (*wrong meaning — this changes the sense entirely*)

Rule: Always use **have + past participle** after the modal. Never use *had* or a base verb.

▷ Write one sentence for each perfect modal below, about your career or Geopave:

should have:

could have:

would have:

▷ Write the rule in your own words:

1.5 Grammar Point 5: Mixing Modals — *Could have vs Should have*

Be careful! These two are often confused.

✓ “You **could have taken** the other job.” (*It was possible — you had the option.*)

✓ “You **should have taken** the other job.” (*It would have been the better choice — advice in hindsight.*)

✓ “We **could have built** a prototype.” (*We had the ability / resources but didn’t.*)

✓ “We **should have built** a prototype.” (*It was the right thing to do — we made a mistake.*)

▷ Think of a project or decision in your career. Write one sentence with *could have* and one with *should have* about that same situation:

1. *could have*:
2. *should have*:

2 1

Instructions: Write two short paragraphs (4–5 sentences each). Use **at least three modal structures** from Part 1 in each paragraph. The prompts are based on your own life and career.

Useful Phrase Starters

Looking back, I think I should have ...	If I could have changed one thing, ...
At the time, nobody would have expected...	I could have chosen..., but instead...
In my opinion, young engineers should ...	If the government would only...
One mistake was that I should have ...	With more support, we could ...

Paragraph 1 — Reflection on your career at KGM

Think about your 30 years at KGM. What would you have done differently? What should the organisation have done better? What could have been improved?

Paragraph 2 — Advice to a 35-year-old engineer thinking about starting their own company

Use your experience with Geopave. What should they do? What mistakes could they avoid? What would you have wished someone had told you?

3 1

Instructions: Answer each question in 3–5 sentences. Write naturally, as if speaking to someone you just met. **Try to use at least one modal verb in every answer.**

Q1: Is there anything you *could have* done differently when you first started Geopave? What *would* you change if you *could* go back?

Q2: Turkey's road network is large and complex. What do you think the government *should* do to modernise road maintenance? What technology *could* help?

Q3: You have a lot of specialised knowledge about pavement engineering. Do you think you *should have* shared more of it publicly earlier in your career? Why or why not?

Q4: Imagine a junior engineer asks you: “*Should I stay in my government job, or should I start something on my own?*” What *would* you say to them?

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These words and phrases all work naturally alongside modal verbs. Try to use **4–5** of them in your homework answers above!

Section A — Key Modal Expressions

#	Expression	Example	Notes
1	<i>should have known better</i>	“I should have known better than to trust that contractor.”	regret about a bad judgement
2	<i>could have sworn</i>	“I could have sworn the report was finished yesterday.”	strong (wrong) belief
3	<i>would have thought</i>	“I would have thought the ministry would share the data.”	expectation that wasn't met
4	<i>might have been</i>	“The delay might have been caused by budget issues.”	softer possibility in the past
5	<i>ought to</i>	“Engineers ought to document everything carefully.”	similar to <i>should</i> — slightly more formal
6	<i>need not have</i>	“We need not have worried — the results were excellent.”	unnecessary action in hindsight
7	<i>must have</i>	“The prototype must have impressed the committee.”	logical deduction about the past
8	<i>can't have</i>	“He can't have finished the analysis already — it takes days.”	impossibility in the past

Section B — Vocabulary for Reflection & Regret

#	Word / Phrase	Example	Synonyms
1	<i>in retrospect</i>	“In retrospect, I should have retired two years earlier.”	looking back, with hindsight
2	<i>to overlook</i>	“We could have overlooked a critical flaw in the data.”	to miss, to fail to notice
3	<i>to underestimate</i>	“I would never have underestimated the cost if I had more experience.”	to misjudge, to miscalculate
4	<i>feasible</i>	“This could have been feasible with a larger budget.”	possible, achievable, viable
5	<i>contingency plan</i>	“We should have had a contingency plan for the delay.”	backup plan, fallback strategy
6	<i>to foresee</i>	“Nobody could have foreseen how quickly the road deteriorated.”	to predict, to anticipate
7	<i>regrettably</i>	“Regrettably, the project should have started six months earlier.”	unfortunately, sadly
8	<i>to capitalise on</i>	“We could have capitalised on that government contract.”	to make the most of, to exploit
9	<i>transparent</i>	“Data sharing should be more transparent in Turkey.”	open, clear, accountable
10	<i>to neglect</i>	“The ministry should not have neglected rural road maintenance.”	to ignore, to fail to maintain

Choose **3 words or expressions** from the tables above and write one sentence each. Each sentence must contain a **modal verb** (would / could / should + perfect form if possible).

1. Word / Expression: _____

2. Word / Expression: _____

3. Word / Expression: _____

Modal	Present / Future	Perfect Form	Use
would	I would do it.	I would have done it.	hypothetical, polite, past habit
could	It could work.	It could have worked.	ability, possibility, suggestion
should	You should try.	You should have tried.	advice, regret, expectation
might	It might happen.	It might have happened.	weak possibility
must	It must be true.	It must have been true.	logical deduction
ought to	You ought to check.	You ought to have checked.	formal advice / duty
need not	You need not worry.	You need not have worried.	unnecessary action

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